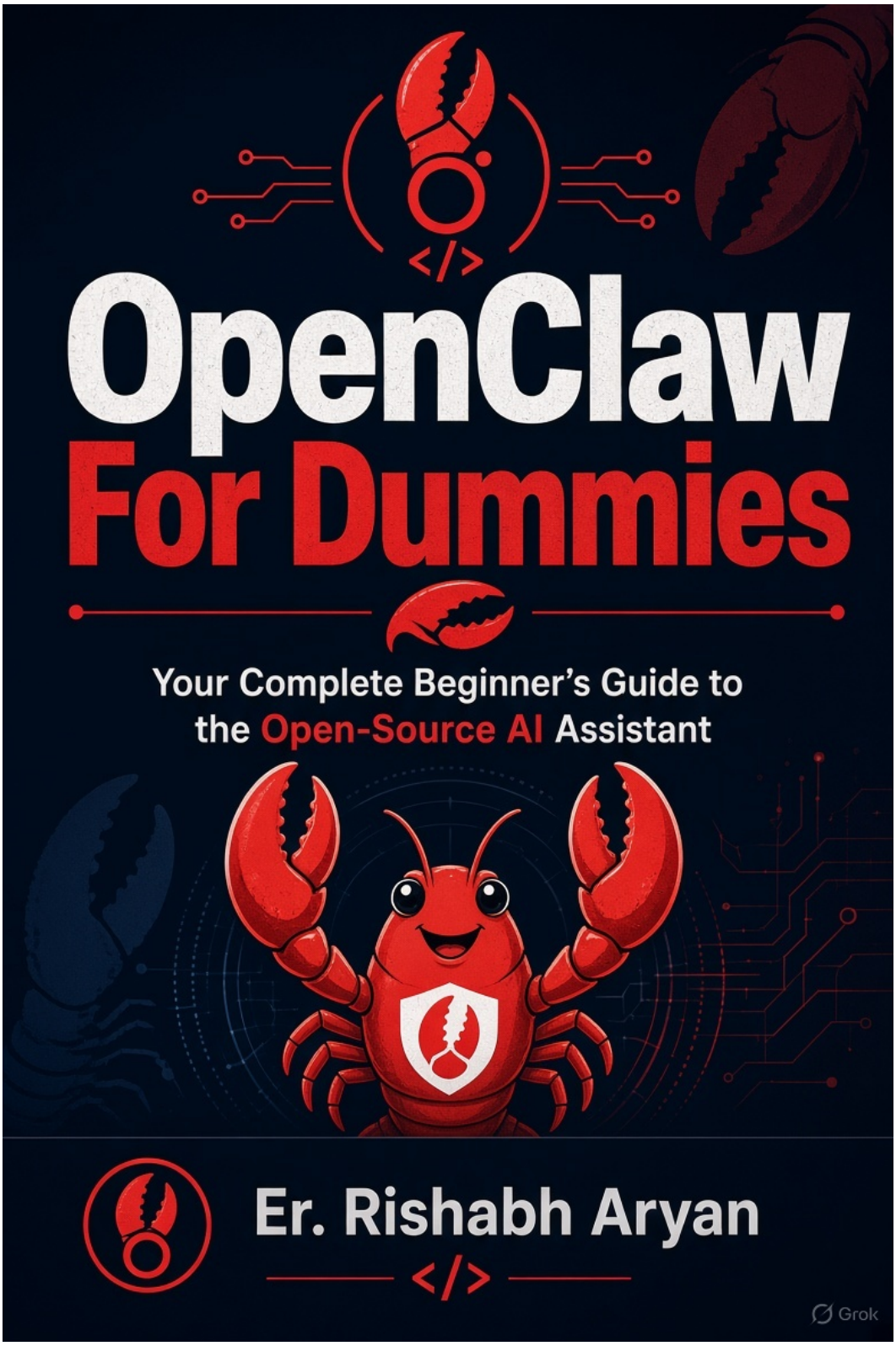

OpenClaw
For Dummies
Your Complete Beginner's Guide to
the Open-Source AI Assistant
Er. Rishabh Aryan
Grok

OpenClaw For Dummies

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the Open-Source AI Assistant

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Introduction

Welcome to OpenClaw For Dummies

OpenClaw is a free, open-source AI assistant that runs on your own hardware. It connects large language models (such as Claude, GPT, or local models) to the messaging apps and tools you already use—WhatsApp, Telegram, Discord, Slack, and others—so the assistant can take real actions on your computer and services.

Unlike cloud chatbots, OpenClaw keeps state, memory, and credentials under your control. It is model-agnostic, extensible via skills and plugins, and designed for both personal use and shared team deployments. The project's lobster mascot, Molty, reflects its history of growth and community-driven development.

REMEMBER

OpenClaw is the control plane and harness, not the model itself. You bring or connect the language model; OpenClaw handles routing, tools, memory, and channels.

This guide walks beginners through installation, configuration, everyday use, and safe practices so you can run a capable personal or team AI assistant on infrastructure you control.

Chapter 1

What OpenClaw Is and Why It Matters

OpenClaw began as a weekend project (originally named Clawd / Moltbot) and rapidly became one of the most starred open-source AI projects. It provides a local Gateway that acts as the always-on control plane, bridging messaging channels to AI agents that can read files, control browsers, run commands, and call tools.

Key Characteristics

• Local-first or self-hosted: runs on your laptop, homelab, or VPS.

• Channel-native: interact through WhatsApp, Telegram, Slack, Discord, iMessage, and more.

• Model-agnostic: works with Anthropic, OpenAI, OpenRouter, local models, and others.

• Stateful: persistent sessions and memory.

• Extensible: skills, plugins, and a community ecosystem (ClawHub).

• Open source (MIT license) and stewarded by the OpenClaw Foundation.

TIP

Because OpenClaw has deep system access when configured that way, start with limited permissions and expand only after you understand the risks.

Chapter 2

Installing and Setting Up OpenClaw

Installation is supported on macOS, Linux, and Windows. The official installer provisions a Node.js runtime when needed.

1. Visit openclaw.ai or the GitHub repository for the latest instructions.

2. On macOS/Linux: run the provided install script (curl -fsSL https://openclaw.ai/install.sh | bash).

3. On Windows: use the PowerShell installer.

4. Follow the prompts to start the Gateway.

5. Open the Control UI or connect via CLI/TUI to complete initial configuration.

6. Verify the Gateway is running and accessible.

REMEMBER

Always obtain installation scripts and binaries from the official openclaw.ai domain or the verified GitHub repository to avoid supply-chain risks.

Chapter 3

Connecting Channels and Models

After the Gateway is running, connect one or more messaging channels and configure at least one language model provider.

Channels

Supported surfaces include WhatsApp, Telegram, Discord, Slack, Signal, iMessage, Google Chat, and others via plugins. Each channel becomes a way to talk to your assistant and receive responses or proactive updates.

Models

Configure API keys or local endpoints for models from Anthropic, OpenAI, OpenRouter, MiniMax, or local runners such as Ollama. You can set per-agent routing and failover. Local models keep all inference on your hardware.

> **TIP**
>
> Begin with a single channel and a single model. Once that works reliably, add more channels or agents.

Chapter 4

Using the Assistant and Skills

Once connected, message your OpenClaw assistant through any linked channel. It maintains session context, can use tools (files, browser, shell, etc., depending on permissions), and can execute multi-step tasks.

Skills

Skills are directories containing a SKILL.md file that teach the agent how to perform specific tasks or call tools. Skills can be bundled, installed globally, or kept in a workspace. The community shares skills via ClawHub and GitHub.

1. Send a simple greeting or status request to confirm the channel works.

2. Ask the assistant to perform a low-risk task (list files in a directory, summarize a document).

3. Review what tools it used and the results.

4. Install or write additional skills for recurring workflows.

5. Use the Control UI to monitor sessions and adjust settings.

Chapter 5

Security, Privacy, and Best Practices

OpenClaw’s power comes from its ability to act on your system and services. Treat it with the same caution you would give any agent that has file and network access.

- Run with the minimum permissions required for your use case.
- Keep the Gateway and host system updated.
- Use strong authentication for channels and the Control UI.
- Review agent actions, especially those involving external services or sensitive files.
- Prefer local models when data must never leave your infrastructure.
- Back up configuration and consider the implications of shared team sessions.
- Never paste credentials into chat; use the secure configuration mechanisms provided.

WARNING

An agent with broad tool access can modify files, send messages, or interact with external APIs. Understand and constrain those capabilities before enabling them.

Chapter 6

Advanced Features and the Ecosystem

OpenClaw 2.0 and later versions add collaborative sessions, improved setup detection of existing subscriptions and local models, enhanced memory, and expanded plugin support. An Enterprise-oriented control plane (OpenClaw Enterprise) is also under development for multi-tenant and higher-security environments.

Community and Resources

The project is highly community-driven. Skills, plugins, and contributions flow through GitHub and ClawHub. Documentation lives at docs.openclaw.ai. The official site is openclaw.ai and the primary repository is github.com/openclaw/openclaw.

> **TIP**
>
> Join the community Discord or follow the GitHub repository for updates, new skills, and security announcements.

Appendix A

Glossary of Terms

Gateway: The always-on local control plane that manages sessions, tools, events, and channel connections.

Channel: A messaging surface (WhatsApp, Telegram, Slack, etc.) through which you interact with the assistant.

Skill: A packaged set of instructions (typically SKILL.md) that teaches the agent how to perform a task or use a tool.

Molty: The lobster mascot of the OpenClaw project.

Model-agnostic: The ability to work with many different language model providers or local runners.

ClawHub: Community hub for sharing skills and plugins.

Appendix B

Quick Reference and Resources

Official Resources

• Website: openclaw.ai

• Documentation: docs.openclaw.ai

• GitHub: github.com/openclaw/openclaw

• Install scripts and getting-started guides on the official site

• Community Discord and ClawHub for skills

About the Author

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This guide is an independent educational resource. OpenClaw is an open-source project. Features, installation methods, and capabilities evolve rapidly. Always consult the official documentation and repository for the most current information and security guidance.